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How World Cup Mobility Put Transit and Motorcoaches to the Test

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FIFA World Cup Matches Are Driving Record Transit Ridership Nationwide

See how World Cup matches are generating record transit demand across North America, with ridership surpassing Super Bowls, concerts, and Olympic-era events.



Elora Haynes • Associate Editor

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June 18, 2026



With parking limited around many World Cup venues and host cities encouraging sustainable transportation options, agencies report that large numbers of fans are choosing rail and bus networks as their primary means of accessing stadiums.

Credit: METRO

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- **FIFA World Cup matches are causing a surge in transit ridership across North America.**
- **Current transit demand due to these matches exceeds that of Super Bowls, concerts, and past Olympic events.**
- **This trend highlights the World Cup's significant impact on public transportation use.**

**Summarized by AI*

Public transit agencies across North America are reporting record-breaking ridership in the opening weeks of the FIFA World Cup, highlighting the critical role transit systems play in moving [hundreds of thousands of fans](#) to matches and related events.

Agencies have reported ridership levels surpassing some of the largest events in recent history, including Super Bowls, major concerts, and even Olympic benchmarks.

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In the San Francisco Bay Area, the Santa Clara [Valley Transportation Authority](#) (VTA), working alongside BART and Caltrain, transported 37,642 passengers to and from the opening World Cup match between Qatar and Switzerland on June 13 at Levi's Stadium, temporarily renamed San Francisco Bay Area Stadium for the tournament.



[Transit Agencies Nationwide
Gear Up to Move World Cup
Crowds](#)

The figure set a new transit ridership record for a major event at the venue and exceeded transit demand recorded during [Super Bowl LX](#) by more than 6,000 passengers.

Just as notable was VTA's post-match performance. Despite a significant surge of fans leaving the stadium after the game, the

agency cleared light rail platforms serving the venue in less than 90 minutes, outperforming the two-hour benchmark typically used for major events.

"This was a tremendous success for VTA and our regional transit partners," said VTA General Manager and CEO [Carolyn Gonot](#). "Thousands of fans chose transit to get to and from the match, and together with BART and Caltrain, we provided a seamless travel experience that kept people moving and got them home safely."

More recently, VTA reported carrying more than 39,500 passengers to and from the Austria-Jordan match on June 16, surpassing the previous tournament record set during the Bay Area opener by approximately 2,500 riders.

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Regional Rails Help Break Ridership Records During Event

Regional rail partners also reported significant increases in demand. BART recorded a more than 160% increase in ridership at Milpitas Station compared with the previous weekend, while Caltrain carried nearly 7,000 fans traveling to and from the match.

A similar trend emerged north of the border in Vancouver, where [TransLink](#) reported its busiest Saturday ridership for a BC Place event since the 2010 Winter Olympics during the city's first FIFA World Cup 2026 match.

According to preliminary data, TransLink recorded more than one million boardings and approximately 648,200 trips systemwide on June 13, representing an 18% increase over a typical Saturday. Ridership at stations serving BC Place exceeded previous event-day records set by Taylor Swift's Eras Tour and Lionel Messi's local match.

SkyTrain ridership increased by nearly 25% compared with a typical Saturday, reaching almost 450,000 boardings, while SeaBus experienced the largest percentage gain, with ridership rising more than 37%.



Additional staffing and crowd-management measures will be deployed at key stations in Guadalajara, including Estadio Chivas, to help ensure safe, efficient fan movement.

Credit: SITEUR

In [Guadalajara](#), Mexico, transit officials are proactively expanding service throughout the tournament. The Urban Electric Train System (SITEUR) announced a special World Cup mobility plan that includes a 12.2% increase in Light Rail capacity, adding nearly 27,000 passenger spaces during the event.

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Light Rail Lines 1, 2, and 3, along with the Macro Periférico bus rapid transit system and Line 5 Macro Airport service, will extend operating hours by up to four hours after matches at Estadio Guadalajara. Additional staffing and crowd-management measures will be deployed at key stations, including Estadio Chivas, to help ensure safe, efficient fan movement.

The expanded service reflects the extensive planning underway across host cities as agencies prepare for sustained demand throughout the month-long tournament.

The World Cup Is Truly a Month-Long Transit Stress Test

The early results suggest that the FIFA World Cup is becoming one of the largest [transit-demand](#) generators ever experienced by many host cities. Unlike single-day events such as the Super Bowl, the month-long tournament creates repeated opportunities for agencies to test crowd management strategies, regional coordination, and service scalability across multiple matches and fan events.

Transit agencies have responded by deploying additional trains, expanding staffing levels, coordinating transfers between regional operators, and implementing enhanced crowd-management plans designed to move large numbers of spectators efficiently while maintaining regular service for residents.

The strong turnout also reflects a shift toward transit use for [major sporting events](#). With parking limited around many World Cup venues and host cities encouraging sustainable transportation options, agencies report that large numbers of fans are choosing rail and bus networks as their primary means of accessing stadiums.

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With dozens of matches still to be played across North America, agencies will continue to monitor ridership trends as the tournament progresses. If early numbers are any indication, additional records may be broken before the World Cup concludes.

When Routine Fails: [How Public Transit Must Adapt for the World Cup](#)

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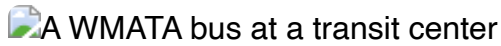
 Two MBTA railcars in station.

SECURITY AND SAFETY · by Staff and News Reports ·
September 21, 2026

FTA Ends Direct Oversight of MBTA Safety Actions

The federal agency closed its remaining special directive to the Massachusetts Department of Public Utilities following a safety review that began in 2022.

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A WMATA bus at a transit center

BUS • by Alex Roman • September 21, 2026

Report: Transit Bus Manufacturing Supports 34,100 Jobs, \$5.1B in GDP

The “Buses Mean Business” report examines the transit bus manufacturing industry’s economic footprint, supply chain, and rising demand for vehicle replacements.

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LIT 10-Year Anniversary Graphic

MANAGEMENT • by Alex Roman • September 17, 2026

LIT Marks 10-Year Milestone at Annual Summit

Hosted by the COTA from September 10 to 13, the Summit carried the theme “Celebrating 10 Years of Excellence, Leadership, and Impact,” with every part of the program honoring the people, agencies, and partners who built LIT over its first decade.

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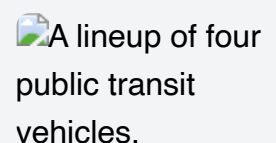
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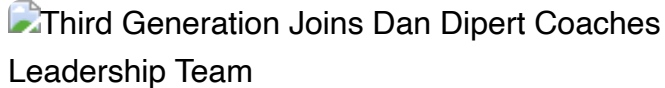
From Our Partners

FTA Opens \$610M for Transit Fleet Modernization

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Propane autogas gives transit agencies a reliable, funding-eligible option for fleet upgrades.

A lineup of four public transit vehicles.

Third Generation Joins Dan Dipert Coaches Leadership Team

MANAGEMENT • by Alex Roman • September 17, 2026

People Movement: Dan Dipert Coaches Adds Third-Generation Leader, Keolis Names New Valley Metro VP/GM, and More

In this edition, we also cover recent appointments and announcements at the Wabtec, SilverRide, HNTB, and more, showcasing the individuals helping to shape the future of transportation.

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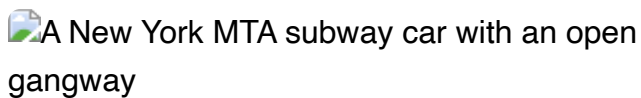
AAAHI receiving METRO's Innovative Operator of the Year Award

MOTORCOACH • by Alex Roman • September 16, 2026

METRO Opens Submissions for 2026 Motorcoach Awards

Nominations are now being accepted for METRO Magazine's Operator of the Year and Innovative Operator of the Year awards.

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A New York MTA subway car with an open gangway

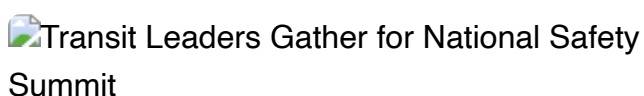
RAIL • by Staff and News Reports • September 16, 2026

New York MTA Advances Final Contract for Second Avenue Subway Expansion

Contract Four is the largest in the Second Avenue Subway Phase 2 project and includes construction of station infrastructure, tracks, and signals for the subway expansion, MTA officials said. Work on Contract Four will begin in 2027.

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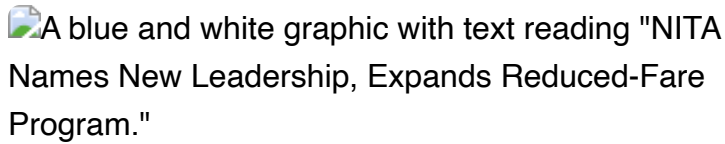
Transit Leaders Gather for National Safety Summit

SECURITY AND SAFETY • by Alex Roman • September 16, 2026

Transit Agencies Highlight Safety Gains at National Summit

Leaders from 15 major transit systems shared crime-reduction results and safety initiatives while discussing the role of continued federal support.

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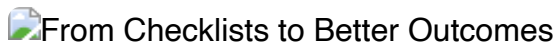
A blue and white graphic with text reading "NITA Names New Leadership, Expands Reduced-Fare Program."

MANAGEMENT • by Staff and News Reports • September 14, 2026

NITA Names New Leadership, Expands Reduced-Fare Program at First Board Meeting

The new regional transit authority appointed its first board chair and interim executive director while extending reduced fares across CTA, Metra, and Pace for eligible riders.

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From Checklists to Better Outcomes

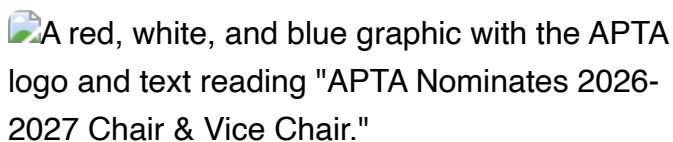
TECHNOLOGY • September 11, 2026

Beyond the Checklist: A Structured Approach to Transit Maintenance

Reliability-Centered Maintenance helps transit agencies move beyond routine checklists to focus limited resources on the assets and failures that have the greatest impact on safety, reliability, and service.

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A red, white, and blue graphic with the APTA logo and text reading "APTA Nominates 2026-2027 Chair & Vice Chair."

MANAGEMENT • by Staff and News Reports • September 10, 2026

APTA 2026 Nominating Committee Selects Leadership Slate, Names Chair and Vice Chair Nominees

Leadership changes will help shape the association's priorities and its representation of the transportation industry during the 2026–2027 term.

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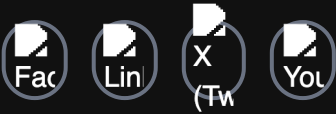
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